

Windows 8 Hybrids and Convertibles

Flexibility is the main benefit of Windows 8 hybrid tablets and convertible ultrabooks; you can flip, fold, slide or detach the screen completely for use as a portable tablet. Also, the battery life is usually quite good, with some models claiming as much as 10 hours. However, the form factor and features need to justify the steep price of the model you buy



UMA GUPTA

The declining sales of PCs due to the growing popularity of tablets have forced PC makers to come up with a new breed of devices called hybrid tablets and convertible ultrabooks. These devices are designed to provide the portability of a tablet and the power of an ultrabook. Thanks to Windows 8's touch-friendly features, these touch-based laptops double up as tablets by either completely detaching the screen or sliding or folding back the screen. Windows 8 has also enabled huge security improvements, longer battery life and faster boot.

"New-age users are frequently switching between the office and the road, the desk and the sofa, type and touch, business and social life, work and pleasure, and desire a device that adapts perfectly to this dynamic lifestyle. Convertible PCs are versatile and deliver superior experience in both modes—a great laptop experience in laptop mode and a great tablet experience in tablet mode. Convertible

PCs have the potential to become the next big ubiquitous computing product," says Saji Kumar, director-product management, Acer India.

Hewlett Packard (HP), Lenovo, Dell, Acer, ASUS and Samsung are the companies betting big on these laptops-cum-tablets. The devices could be powered by processors like Intel Core i-series (found in ultrabooks), netbook-class Intel Atom or Nvidia Tegra.

Hybrids are basically two separate devices. These are tablets that can be used with optional, detachable keyboards to work as notebooks. More powerful than regular tablet devices, these are ideal for those who need to frequently type documents. Other hybrids are those where the tablet snaps onto a keyboard dock to form a single laptop device.

"A Windows tablet can blend seamlessly in an office ecosystem, thereby ensuring uninterrupted productivity. Depending on the portability requirement, customers can select from three tablet sizes of 20.3 cm (8 inches), 25.4 cm (10 inches) and 29.5 cm (11.6 inches). These devices will have a distinct advantage over their competition if they come preloaded with the complete MS Office suite. Equipped with a suite of connectivity options including micro HDMI/USB ports, they will deliver seamless connectivity and enable better productivity," shares Kumar.

Examples of hybrids include HP Envy X2 and Split X2, ASUS Vivo Tab and Asus Transformer Book TX300, Samsung Ativ PC Pro, Microsoft Surface, Lenovo ThinkPad Helix and Acer Iconia W3-810.

Talking of convertible PCs, these are basically ultrabooks that can transform into tablets. There are several variations within this category. For instance, these include dual-screen models, sliding-screen models, flip-screen models and laptops with touchscreens. Examples are Dell XPS 12 (an ultrabook that transforms to a tablet with a fluid flip-and-fold motion with its premium flip-hinge design), Lenovo IdeaPad Yoga 13 (which has four modes of use—standard laptop mode, tablet mode, 'tent' mode and 'stand' mode), Sony VAIO Duo 11 and ASUS Taichi.

Common screen sizes include 29.5 cm (11.6 inches), 31.8 cm (12.5 inches) and 33.8 cm (13.3 inches). In terms of pricing, convertibles usually cost higher than hybrid models.

Buying criteria

Peter Chang, regional head of South Asia and managing director for ASUS India, advises, "While buying a Windows